Mark Scheme (Results)

Summer 2026

Pearson Edexcel GCSE
in History (1HI0)
Paper B4: British depth study

B4: Early Elizabethan England, 1558–88

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General Marking Guidance

- All candidates must receive the same treatment. Examiners must mark the first candidate in exactly the same way as they mark the last.
- Mark schemes should be applied positively. Candidates must be rewarded for what they have shown they can do rather than penalised for omissions.
- Examiners should mark according to the mark scheme not according to their perception of where the grade boundaries may lie.
- There is no ceiling on achievement. All marks on the mark scheme should be used appropriately.
- All the marks on the mark scheme are designed to be awarded. Examiners should always award full marks if deserved, i.e. if the answer matches the mark scheme. Examiners should also be prepared to award zero marks if the candidate's response is not worthy of credit according to the mark scheme.
- Where some judgement is required, mark schemes will provide the principles by which marks will be awarded and exemplification may be limited.
- When examiners are in doubt regarding the application of the mark scheme to a candidate's response, the team leader must be consulted.
- Crossed out work should be marked UNLESS the candidate has replaced it with an alternative response.

How to award marks when level descriptions are used

1. **Finding the right level**

The first stage is to decide which level the answer should be placed in. To do this, use a 'best-fit' approach, deciding which level most closely describes the quality of the answer. Answers can display characteristics from more than one level, and where this happens markers must use the guidance below and their professional judgement to decide which level is most appropriate. For example, one stronger passage at L4 would not by itself merit a L4 mark, but it might be evidence to support a high L3 mark, unless there are substantial weaknesses in other areas. Similarly, an answer that fits best in L3 but which has some characteristics of L2 might be placed at the bottom of L3. An answer displaying some characteristics of L3 and some of L1 might be placed in L2.

2. **Finding a mark within a level**

After a level has been decided on, the next stage is to decide on the mark within the level. The instructions below tell you how to reward responses within a level. However, where a level has specific guidance about how to place an answer within a level, always follow that guidance.

Levels containing two marks only

Start with the presumption that the work will be at the top of the level. Move down to the lower mark if the work only just meets the requirements of the level.

Levels containing three or more marks

Markers should be prepared to use the full range of marks available in a level and not restrict marks to the middle. Markers should start at the middle of the level (or the upper-middle mark if there is an even number of marks) and then move the mark up or down to find the best mark. To do this, they should take into account how far the answer meets the requirements of the level:

- If it meets the requirements *fully*, markers should be prepared to award full marks within the level. The top mark in the level is used for answers that are as good as can realistically be expected within that level.
- If it only *barely* meets the requirements of the level, markers should consider awarding marks at the bottom of the level. The bottom mark in the level is used for answers that are the weakest that can be expected within that level.
- The middle marks of the level are used for answers that have a *reasonable* match to the descriptor. This might represent a balance between some characteristics of the level that are fully met and others that are only barely met.

Indicative content

Examiners are reminded that indicative content is provided as an illustration to markers of some of the material that may be offered by students. It does not show required content and alternatives should be credited where valid.

B4: Early Elizabethan England, 1558–88

Question	
1 (a)	Describe **one** feature of poverty in early Elizabethan England. **Target**: Knowledge of key features and characteristics of the period. **AO1**: 2 marks.
Marking instructions	
Award one mark for a valid feature identified. The second mark should be awarded for supporting information. e.g. • *A cause of poverty in early Elizabethan England was a series of bad harvests* ***(1)*** *that led to rising food costs* ***(1)****.* • *Poor people in early Elizabethan England were put into categories* ***(1)****, such as the deserving poor and the idle poor* ***(1)****.* • *Laws were passed to help provide relief for the poor* ***(1)****, such as the 1563 Act for the Relief of the Poor (Statute of Artificers)* ***(1)****.* Accept other appropriate features and supporting information.	

Question	
1 (b)	Describe **one** feature of the attempted colonisation of Virginia. **Target**: knowledge of key features and characteristics of the period. **AO1**: 2 marks.
Marking instructions	
Award one mark for a valid feature identified. The second mark should be awarded for supporting information. e.g. • *The colonists did not have enough food* ***(1)****, as they arrived too late to plant their crops* ***(1)****.* • *The wealthy colonists were not willing to undertake manual work* ***(1)*** *and the poorer colonists did not want to work for the wealthy ones* ***(1)****.* • *The colonists were reliant on the local Indigenous people for food* ***(1)*** *but ended up at war with them* ***(1)****.* Accept other appropriate features and supporting information.	

Question		
2		Explain why the Revolt of the Northern Earls (1569-70) was a threat to Elizabeth I. You **may** use the following in your answer: • Mary, Queen of Scots • relations between England and Spain You **must** also use information of your own. **Target**: Analysis of second order concepts: causation [AO2]; Knowledge and understanding of features and characteristics [AO1]. **AO2**: 6 marks. **AO1**: 6 marks.
Level	**Mark**	**Descriptor**
	0	No rewardable material.
1	**1–3**	• A simple or generalised answer is given, lacking development and organisation. [AO2] • Limited knowledge and understanding of the topic is shown. [AO1]
2	**4–6**	• An explanation is given showing limited analysis and with implicit or unsustained links to the conceptual focus of the question. It shows some development and organisation of material, but a line of reasoning is not sustained. [AO2] • Accurate and relevant information is included, showing some knowledge and understanding of the period. [AO1]
3	**7–9**	• An explanation is given, showing some analysis, which is mainly directed at the conceptual focus of the question. It shows a line of reasoning that is generally sustained, although some passages may lack coherence and organisation. [AO2] • Accurate and relevant information is included, showing good knowledge and understanding of the required features or characteristics of the period studied. [AO1] *Maximum 8 marks for answers that do not address three or more aspects of content.*
4	**10–12**	• An analytical explanation is given which is directed consistently at the conceptual focus of the question, showing a line of reasoning that is coherent, sustained and logically structured. [AO2] • Accurate and relevant information is precisely selected to address the question directly, showing wide-ranging knowledge and understanding of the required features or characteristics of the period studied. [AO1] *No access to Level 4 for answers that do not address three or more aspects of content.*

Marking instructions

Markers must apply the descriptors above in line with the general marking guidance (page 3).

Performance in AO1 and AO2 is interdependent. An answer displaying **no** qualities of AO2 cannot be awarded more than the top of Level 1, no matter how strong performance is in AO1; markers should note that the expectation for AO1 is that candidates demonstrate both knowledge *and* understanding.

The middle mark in each level may be achieved by stronger performance in either AO1 or AO2.

Indicative content guidance

Answers must be credited according to candidates' deployment of material in relation to the qualities outlined in the mark scheme. While specific references are made in the indicative content below, this does not imply that these must be included; other relevant material must also be credited.

Relevant points may include:

- Elizabeth's position on the throne was threatened because the Northern Earls planned for Mary, Queen of Scots, to replace Elizabeth as queen.
- Relations between England and Spain were increasingly tense, due to political, commercial and religious rivalry. This meant that the threat of a foreign invasion in support of the plot was increased.
- Many of the rebels opposed Elizabeth's closest political advisers and wanted them to be removed, threatening the stability of Elizabeth's government.
- The Revolt of the Northern Earls threatened the security of Elizabeth's religious settlement, because the earls intended to restore the Catholic faith in England.
- The Revolt led to Elizabeth's excommunication by the Pope in 1570, leading to further plots against her position, such as the Throckmorton plot.
- The rebellion clearly showed that Catholics presented a threat and that this was at all levels of society.

Question		
3		'Financial weakness was Elizabeth's main problem when she became queen in 1558.' How far do you agree? Explain your answer. You **may** use the following in your answer: • the Crown's debt • Elizabeth's legitimacy You **must** also use information of your own. **Target**: Analysis and evaluation of second order concepts: significance [AO2]; Knowledge and understanding of features and characteristics [AO1]. **AO2**: 10 marks. **AO1**: 6 marks.
Level	**Mark**	**Descriptor**
	0	No rewardable material.
1	**1–4**	• A simple or generalised answer is given, lacking development and organisation. [AO2] • Limited knowledge and understanding of the topic is shown. [AO1] • The overall judgement is missing or asserted. [AO2]
2	**5–8**	• An explanation is given showing limited analysis and with implicit or unsustained links to the conceptual focus of the question. It shows some development and organisation of material, but a line of reasoning is not sustained. [AO2] • Accurate and relevant information is included, showing some knowledge and understanding of the period. [AO1] • The overall judgement is given but its justification is asserted or insecure. [AO2]
3	**9–12**	• An explanation is given, showing some analysis, which is mainly directed at the conceptual focus of the question. It shows a line of reasoning that is generally sustained, although some passages may lack coherence and organisation. [AO2] • Accurate and relevant information is included, showing good knowledge and understanding of the required features or characteristics of the period studied. [AO1] • The overall judgement is given with some justification, but some criteria selected for the required judgement are left implicit or not validly applied. [AO2] *Maximum 11 marks for answers that do not address three or more aspects of content.*
4	**13–16**	• An analytical explanation is given which is directed consistently at the conceptual focus of the question, showing a line of reasoning that is coherent, sustained and logically structured. [AO2] • Accurate and relevant information is precisely selected to address the question directly, showing wide-ranging knowledge and understanding of the required features or characteristics of the period studied. [AO1] • Criteria for the required judgement are justified and applied in the process of reaching the overall judgement. [AO2] *No access to Level 4 for answers that do not address three or more aspects of content.*

Marking instructions

Markers must apply the descriptors above in line with the general marking guidance (page 3).

Performance in AO1 and AO2 is interdependent. An answer displaying **no** qualities of AO2 cannot be awarded more than the top of Level 1, no matter how strong performance is in AO1; markers should note that the expectation for AO1 is that candidates demonstrate both knowledge *and* understanding.

The first two bullet points *[AO1 and AO2]* account for 3 of the 4 marks in the level and are equally weighted; the third bullet point *[AO2]* accounts for the remaining mark. Once the level has been found, there are two steps to follow to determine the mark within the level:

- Markers should consider bullet points 1 and 2 together. Strong performance (for the level) in both would be awarded all 3 marks, while 2 marks may be achieved by stronger performance in either bullet point; weak performance would be awarded 1 mark.
- The fourth mark in each level is allocated to the bullet point 3 and should be considered independently of the award of the other marks.

Indicative content guidance

Answers must be credited according to candidates' deployment of material in relation to the qualities outlined in the mark scheme. While specific references are made in the indicative content below, this does not imply that these must be included; other relevant material must also be credited. The grouping of points below does not imply that this is how candidates are expected to structure their answers.

Relevant points which support the statement may include:

- The Crown's debt in 1558 was around £300,000, which was more than its annual income, making it difficult for Elizabeth to pay off the debt.
- Due to the Crown's debt, it was difficult for Elizabeth to pay for the war with France, increasing the threat of being conquered.
- The financial weakness inherited by Elizabeth made it difficult for her to manage affairs of state.

Relevant points which counter the statement may include:

- Elizabeth's legitimacy was questioned by Catholics in England, who did not recognise her father's marriage to Anne Boleyn as legal.
- Mary, Queen of Scots was a legitimate alternative candidate for the throne because she had a direct claim, as Henry VIII's great-niece.
- England was at war with France in 1558 and the French supported Mary, Queen of Scots' claim to the throne.
- There was religious unrest in England in 1558, which threatened Elizabeth's position as she needed to find a way to satisfy both Protestants and Catholics.
- As an unmarried woman, Elizabeth was vulnerable to criticism from people who felt that she was not capable of ruling the country.

Question		
4		'The main reason for the English victory over the Spanish Armada was poor planning by the Spanish.' How far do you agree? Explain your answer. You **may** use the following in your answer: • the leadership of the Duke of Medina Sidonia • the use of fire ships You **must** also use information of your own. **Target**: Analysis and evaluation of second order concepts: causation [AO2]; Knowledge and understanding of features and characteristics [AO1]. **AO2**: 10 marks. **AO1**: 6 marks.
Level	**Mark**	**Descriptor**
	0	No rewardable material.
1	**1–4**	• A simple or generalised answer is given, lacking development and organisation. [AO2] • Limited knowledge and understanding of the topic is shown. [AO1] • The overall judgement is missing or asserted. [AO2]
2	**5–8**	• An explanation is given showing limited analysis and with implicit or unsustained links to the conceptual focus of the question. It shows some development and organisation of material, but a line of reasoning is not sustained. [AO2] • Accurate and relevant information is included, showing some knowledge and understanding of the period. [AO1] • The overall judgement is given but its justification is asserted or insecure. [AO2]
3	**9–12**	• An explanation is given, showing some analysis, which is mainly directed at the conceptual focus of the question. It shows a line of reasoning that is generally sustained, although some passages may lack coherence and organisation. [AO2] • Accurate and relevant information is included, showing good knowledge and understanding of the required features or characteristics of the period studied. [AO1] • The overall judgement is given with some justification, but some criteria selected for the required judgement are left implicit or not validly applied. [AO2] *Maximum 11 marks for answers that do not address three or more aspects of content.*
4	**13–16**	• An analytical explanation is given which is directed consistently at the conceptual focus of the question, showing a line of reasoning that is coherent, sustained and logically structured. [AO2] • Accurate and relevant information is precisely selected to address the question directly, showing wide-ranging knowledge and understanding of the required features or characteristics of the period studied. [AO1] • Criteria for the required judgement are justified and applied in the process of reaching the overall judgement. [AO2] *No access to Level 4 for answers that do not address three or more aspects of content.*

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Relevant points which support the statement may include:

- The leader of the Spanish fleet, the Duke of Medina Sidonia, was inexperienced in naval warfare.
- The Spanish were unable to deploy their usual tactics because their ships were unsuited to conditions in the English Channel.
- The Spanish ships did not carry an invasion force, as they intended to collect soldiers from the Spanish Netherlands. However, they had not secured access to deep-water ports and therefore could not enact this plan.
- The Spanish packed their supplies in new barrels, which were not airtight, resulting in a lot of their food and water spoiling.

Relevant points which counter the statement may include:

- The English sent fire ships into the Spanish fleet while they were at anchor at Gravelines, breaking their formation and making the Spanish ships easier to attack.
- The English navy had smaller, more manoeuvrable ships for use in the English Channel, which enabled successful attacks on the Spanish ships.
- Bad weather disrupted the Armada's formation and prevented it from regrouping.
- Francis Drake had previously led a successful attack on the Spanish naval base at Cadiz, disrupting preparations for the attack.

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